

SCHOOL OF LIFE FOUNDATION

The Architecture of *Grace*



BOOK THREE · THE INTERIOR

Autism-Adapted Edition

Visual Anchor Charts

TEACHER SUPPLEMENT

Grades 6–8 · Middle School

Designed for autistic learners with lower support needs · one chart per page

Twenty-eight printable anchor charts · One per page

Before You Begin

What Book Three asks of an autism-aware classroom

This supplement is not a new curriculum. It is the same twenty-eight anchor charts from *Architecture of Grace · Book Three · The Interior*, rebuilt by a multidisciplinary team — autism specialist, school psychologist, school social worker, special education teacher, speech-language pathologist, and occupational therapist — with autistic students with lower support needs held as the design audience from the first line.

What did NOT change

- Every defined construct — *Mask*, *Mirror*, *Internal Critic*, *Compassionate Witness*, *Digital Backpack*, *Choice-Agency Map*, *Forgiveness*, *Reconciliation*, *Grace*, *Mercy* — appears exactly as the curriculum defines it.
- The theoretical foundation — Brown, Neff, Enright & Fitzgibbons, Worthington, Frankl, Siegel — is preserved.
- The pedagogy — predictable opening rituals, *Compassionate Witness* standard, *Disclosure Protocol*, counselor co-facilitation on flagged lessons — is unchanged.

What is new in this Book

- **The Mask vs. Mirror chart carries an added panel.** For autistic adolescents, masking is not a universal teen experience — it is documented survival behavior linked to autistic burnout, depression, and elevated suicide risk. The chart now names this directly and states explicitly that *this room is a place where unmasking is allowed*.
- **The Pause and the Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation charts carry a pattern-tracking guardrail.** The “charitable interpretation” framing, taught without this guardrail, can train autistic students to repeatedly override accurate threat detection.
- **The Crisis Resources page carries an autism-specific addendum.** Autistic adolescents are at significantly elevated suicide risk. The team agreed this must be named on the chart — not buried in a footnote.
- **Specialist Notes** appear on every chart, with what to watch for, what to honor, and what to never force.

A NOTE ON GRADES 6–8

Middle school is the highest-stakes period of the curriculum for autistic students. Masking peaks here. Friendships shift from interest-based to status-based, often shutting out autistic peers. Demands for inferential social reading exceed many students’ current capacity. Sensory load is high. *If you are teaching this curriculum to an autistic 6–8 student, assume they are doing more work than you can see to be in your room. Design accordingly.*

Mask vs. Mirror

Who am I when I’m performing — and who am I when I’m not?

THE MASK · WHAT I SHOW	THE MIRROR · WHAT IS TRUE
Perform. What I emphasize for the audience in front of me.	Real opinions. What I actually think when no one is watching.
Edit. What I leave out, soften, or rewrite for safety.	Actual struggles. What I’m carrying that the Mask never shows.
Hide. What I keep behind the curtain so it can’t be used.	Real values. What I would protect even if no one applauded.

“The gap between these two is where the cost lives.”

A NOTE FOR AUTISTIC STUDENTS IN THIS ROOM

For many autistic people, the Mask is not optional social performance — it is survival behavior built from years of being told who to be. Sustained masking is linked to **autistic burnout**, depression, and exhaustion. Unmasking is not “less effort” — for many autistic people, it is the harder thing to do. **This room is a place where unmasking is allowed.** You do not have to perform here. *Listening looks different in different bodies. Stimming is welcome. Quiet is welcome.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This is the single most important chart in Book Three for autistic students. The original framing treats masking as a universal teen experience — for autistic students it is something specific, documented, and costly. The added panel must be on the chart, and must be read aloud during the lesson. *Watch for students who go very still during the Mirror introduction, or who deflect the discussion entirely. Note privately. Follow Disclosure Protocol if anything else surfaces. Post before class on Day 1. Keep all year.*

Shame vs. Guilt

The most important distinction of Unit 1

SHAME	GUILT
About who I am. “I am bad.”	About what I did. “I made a bad choice.”
Identity-level · Global.	Behavior-level · Specific.
Points toward HIDING. “Why even try? I’m hopeless.”	Points toward REPAIR. “Fix it. Do better. Try again.”
Almost never produces growth.	Produces repair and growth.

“When you hear the inner critic, ask: is this attacking my **behavior**, or my **identity**?”

FOR ANYONE WHO HAS BEEN TOLD WHO THEY ARE

Some students arrive at this lesson with years of being told there is something wrong with *who they are* — by family, by peers, by school systems, by media. **Those messages live in the SHAME column. The shame column is never true about a person.** Being different is not being broken.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

By Grade 6, many autistic students have heard a decade of identity-level feedback — *weird, dramatic, oversensitive, attention-seeking, manipulative, defiant*. Often those labels were applied to behavior that was actually a sensory response, an autistic communication style, or a meltdown from overload. The added panel addresses the cumulative weight of that. Color-code columns. Keep posted all unit. Revisit in Unit 2.

The Digital Backpack

Everything you post, share, react to, and comment on goes in here — and mostly stays

WHAT GOES IN

Posts · Comments · Likes · Shares · Screenshots · Direct Messages · Reactions

MOSTLY PERMANENT

Even deleted content can be screenshot, cached, or remembered. *Delete is not erase.*

POTENTIALLY PUBLIC

Multiple audiences may see what you posted for one. *The audience you imagine is rarely the only one.*

CARRIES LONGER

Things stay longer than you ever intended. *The version of you that posted in Grade 6 still exists.*

“Once it’s in, it stays.”

A NOTE ON ONLINE LIFE

For some students, online communities are where they feel most themselves — where their interests are welcome and their social style is normal. **This chart is not a warning to leave those spaces.** It is a reminder that even in the spaces where you feel most safe to be real — *what you post can travel beyond the people you trusted with it.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

For many autistic students, online life is not a peripheral risk — it is where genuine identity and community happen, often more than at school. The original chart treats the digital backpack as purely a hazard; the added note acknowledges what online life actually is for these students while preserving the warning. Do not frame “less time online” as a universal good in this lesson. The cost-benefit math is different when offline social life is exhausting or hostile. Post before class. Keep Unit 1.

Signal vs. Noise

The volume of integrity — and the noise that drowns it out

SIGNAL · INTEGRITY	NOISE · PEER PRESSURE
The consistent, quiet voice of your values.	Loud, surrounding, hard to hear past.
Always present. Doesn't change with the room.	Changes from room to room, group to group.
Easy to lose track of when the room gets loud.	Wants you to forget the signal exists.

THREE MECHANISMS OF PEER PRESSURE

- 1. **Social Proof** — Everyone is doing it, so it must be right.
- 2. **Fear of Exclusion** — If I don't go along, I lose my seat at the table.
- 3. **Identity Merger** — My group's opinion is my opinion.

“The signal never goes away. The challenge is hearing it past the noise.”

A NOTE ON FEAR OF EXCLUSION

Fear of Exclusion lands differently for students who have already been excluded a lot. If your “seat at the table” has been hard to earn, the cost of losing it feels higher — and the pressure to merge feels stronger. *That is not weakness. That is a reasonable response to a real history. Naming it is the first step in deciding what to do with it.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Two things autism-aware teaching adds here: (1) Many autistic students are *less* susceptible to social proof — they often don't notice the “everyone is doing it” cue, or they notice and dismiss it. That can look like defiance or rigidity to teachers; it is integrity in action. (2) Autistic students often are *more* susceptible to Fear of Exclusion, especially after years of social rejection. The added panel addresses this without pathologizing it. Keep posted all of Unit 1.

Label vs. Integrity

Author of your story

LABEL · FROM THE OUTSIDE	INTEGRITY STATEMENT · FROM THE INSIDE
Assigned by other people.	Claimed by you.
Based on social dynamics, reputation, rumour.	Based on your values, your choices, your authorship.
Tells you what others see.	Tells you who you actually are.
Written by someone else’s story.	Written by you.

THE FOUR PROMPTS

I am ___ · I value ___ · I choose ___ · The story I am telling is ___

“Who gets to write your story?”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

For autistic students, the “Label” column often contains words assigned by adults and peers based on behavior that was actually neurology — *rigid, dramatic, slow, awkward, oversensitive, manipulative*. The four prompts are a corrective: they invite the student to *claim* language for themselves before they accept language from others. Some students will use diagnostic language honestly here (“I am autistic”). That is identity work, not symptom disclosure. Honor it. Post before class. Keep through U1-L7.

The Choice-Agency Map

Three rings · One question: where does your response live?

OUTER RING · OUTSIDE MY CONTROL

What others say. Weather. Past events. Other people’s choices and feelings. *Sensory environments you didn’t pick.*

MIDDLE RING · I CAN INFLUENCE

Conversations I enter. Effort I put in. How I show up. What I model. *Whether I ask for the accommodation I need.*

INNER CIRCLE · I FULLY CHOOSE

My response. My words. My next step. The story I tell myself about what just happened.

“My response always lives in the inner circle.”

FRANKL · ADAPTED

“Between what happens to us and how we respond, there is always a space. In that space is our power to choose.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Sensory environments and accommodations are explicitly named in the outer and middle rings. For autistic students, “what is in your control” cannot mean ignoring overwhelming fluorescent lighting or a fire drill — those genuinely *are* outside their control, and pretending otherwise is gaslighting. **Critical caveat:** when someone is in meltdown or shutdown, the inner circle is temporarily inaccessible — the nervous system has taken over. The chart still applies; recovery requires returning to the inner circle *after* regulation, not during it. Pre-populate the outer ring with 3–4 examples. Reference again in Unit 4.

All Unit 1 Charts

Six concepts, one foundation — displayed simultaneously

All six charts from Unit 1 displayed together. No new chart for this lesson.

L1 · Mask vs. Mirror

Identity & the cost of performance — and the room’s invitation to unmask.

L2 · Shame vs. Guilt

The most important distinction.

L3 · Digital Backpack

Once it’s in, it stays.

L4 · Signal vs. Noise

The volume of integrity.

L5 · Label vs. Integrity

Author of your story.

L6 · Choice-Agency Map

Three rings, one question.

“Look at what this class built.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Allow sixty seconds of silent scanning before any question — autistic students often need processing time before participating, and a fast pivot to discussion shuts them out of the wrap-up. Then ask: what is the most important thing Unit 1 taught you about yourself? Accept any answer, including “I don’t know yet.” That is also a valid answer.

The Internal Critic

Three tactics — plus the Compassionate Witness

WHAT THIS MEANS — IN PLAIN WORDS

The Internal Critic and Compassionate Witness are not real voices — they are names for two different patterns of thinking. Everyone has both. The skill is recognizing which is talking.

THE INTERNAL CRITIC	COMPASSIONATE WITNESS
Catastrophising. “Everything is ruined.”	Honest + specific. “This moment was hard. It will pass.”
Globalising. “I ALWAYS fail. I NEVER get it right.”	Fair + kind. “Sometimes I struggle with this. And I also ____.”
Personalising. “Everything that went wrong is my fault.”	Not a cheerleader. “What is my actual part — and what isn’t?”

“The Compassionate Witness is honest, fair, and kind — without punishment.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The Personalising tactic is especially loud for autistic students — many have absorbed the message that social mishaps are their fault even when the social mishap was a difference in communication style. The Compassionate Witness column’s third row — “What is my actual part, and what isn’t?” — is the corrective. Post before class. Add the Compassionate Witness column live during Step 3. Keep all of Unit 2 and beyond.

Highlight Reel vs. Blooper Reel

You are comparing your bloopers reel to someone else’s highlight reel

HIGHLIGHT REEL · WHAT OTHERS POST	BLOOPER REEL · WHAT YOU LIVE
Curated. Filtered. Best-of.	Your full, unedited experience.
What we see of others online.	The hard moments, the doubts, the failures.
The edited version.	The real version.
A trailer, not the film.	Everything the trailer left out.

THE OWN-YARDSTICK

“Compared to me ___ time ago, I have ___.”
The only honest comparison is to your earlier self.

“That comparison is structurally rigged.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Autistic students often compare not just *achievements* but *social ease* — they watch peers navigate group dynamics that cost them nothing, and conclude they themselves are broken. The Own-Yardstick framework is the corrective: progress is measured against your prior self, not against a neurotypical norm you may never match (and don’t need to). Keep posted Unit 2.

The Perfectionism Spectrum

Not high standards — terror masquerading as ambition

PERFECTIONISM	HEALTHY STRIVING
Failure = I am worthless.	Failure = data I can learn from.
Terror masquerading as ambition.	High standards without self-destruction.
Not starting feels safer than failing.	Effort matters more than outcome.

← Where on this spectrum am I, today, in this subject? →

THE PARADOX

Why does perfectionism look like laziness? **Because not starting is safer than doing it poorly.**

A NOTE ON AUTISTIC PERFECTIONISM

For autistic students, perfectionism often has an extra layer: *if I do not get it exactly right, the rule will be broken — and broken rules cause panic*. This is not vanity; it is a regulation problem. Healthy striving here means: **“I can do my version of this — even if it isn’t the rule’s version.”**

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The “not starting” pattern is common in autistic students and is often misread as defiance or executive dysfunction alone. It is often both *and* perfectionism — the student knows they will not be able to make it match the rule, and freezing is the safest option. The added panel names this. Walk through with care. The discussion question — “*What is the fear underneath the left side?*” — may surface real material. Keep posted Unit 2.

Accountability vs. Self-Punishment

Feeling bad is not the same as taking responsibility · Action is

ACCOUNTABILITY	SELF-PUNISHMENT
<i>“I made a choice that didn’t fit who I want to be.”</i>	<i>“I am bad. I will suffer.”</i>
Forward motion — produces repair.	Focuses on self — produces nothing.
Guilt in action.	Shame in action.

THE FOUR-STEP ACCOUNTABILITY STRUCTURE

- 1. **Honest acknowledgment.** Name the choice and its impact — exactly.
- 2. **Genuine repair.** What can I actually do? Do it.
- 3. **Commitment.** A different choice next time — specific.
- 4. **Move on.** Suffering is not on this list. *These four steps ARE the structure.*

A NOTE ON STEP 4

Some students — especially those with strong justice-sensitivity — will continue punishing themselves long after Step 3 is complete. **The inner standard says: “But what I did was bad. I should still feel bad.”** Step 4 is the correction. Suffering is not repair. *Once you have done the work, the work is done.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Autistic students with strong justice-sensitivity often struggle most with Step 4. Their internal moral standard is high and they cannot easily release themselves from punishment even when they have made repair. The added panel addresses this directly. Two other notes: (1) *impact and intent are separate constructs* — the curriculum already covers this in U3-L1, reference it during this lesson if a student gets stuck on “but I didn’t MEAN to”; (2) honest acknowledgment cannot be coerced — if a student is not ready to name what they did, the rest of the structure stalls. Add the four-step structure live during Step 2 of the lesson.

The Friend Test

The empathy you already have — redirected toward yourself

TO MY BEST FRIEND · WHAT I WOULD SAY	TO MYSELF · WHAT I ACTUALLY SAY
Kind. Fair. Honest.	Often harsh.
Without punishment.	Sometimes cruel.
Holds them to standards while still seeing them whole.	Things I would never say to a friend in the same situation.

“Would you say that to your best friend in the same situation?”

IF YOU DON'T HAVE A BEST FRIEND RIGHT NOW

Some students arrive at this lesson without a current best friend — sometimes because of bullying, exclusion, or moves; sometimes because deep friendship just hasn’t happened yet. **The Friend Test still works:** think of someone you love — a sibling, a cousin, a younger version of yourself, a pet, a fictional character you care about. What would you say to *them*?

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original prompt assumes the student has a best friend currently in their life. Many autistic students at 6–8 do not — through no fault of their own. The added panel preserves the exercise without requiring the student to publicly acknowledge they don’t have a current close friendship. *Watch this lesson carefully — discussion questions about “the gap between these two voices” can surface real material. Note privately. Follow Disclosure Protocol if needed. Keep posted Unit 2 and Unit 3.*

Crisis Resources

Post visibly before students arrive — keep posted for the rest of the year

IF YOU OR SOMEONE YOU KNOW IS IN CRISIS

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — *Call or text 988*
Crisis Text Line — *Text HOME to 741741*

YOUR SCHOOL COUNSELOR

Name: _____

Contact: _____

A NOTE FOR AUTISTIC STUDENTS — AND THE ADULTS WHO LOVE THEM

Research consistently shows that **autistic adolescents face elevated suicide risk** — often connected to bullying, masking exhaustion, loneliness, and being misunderstood. *If you are reading this and any of those things describe your life right now, please reach out. Your life matters. Your way of being in the world is not the problem.*

The resources above answer calls and texts from autistic people, including those who find phone calls hard. Text HOME to 741741 if speaking aloud is not accessible right now.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This is the single most important page in Book Three. Autistic adolescents are at significantly elevated risk for suicide and self-harm compared to the general population. The added panel names this risk and explicitly tells autistic students that text-based crisis support exists for those who cannot or will not speak on a phone. The room must be calm and minimal for U2·L6 — visual environment quiet, counselor physically in the room before any student arrives, letter templates face-down at seats. Crisis resources must remain visible for the rest of the year.

All Unit 2 Charts

Six charts, one unit · Return U2·L1 journals before this lesson

L1 · Internal Critic

Three tactics — plus the Compassionate Witness.

L2 · Highlight vs. Blooper

The comparison is structurally rigged.

L3 · Perfectionism Spectrum

Terror masquerading as ambition.

L4 · Accountability vs. Self-Punishment

Action, not suffering.

L5 · The Friend Test

Redirect the empathy you already have.

L6 · Crisis Resources

Permanently posted. For the rest of the year.

“Look at what this unit asked of you. You did that work.”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Unit 2 is heavy — by design. Some autistic students will be visibly exhausted by this point in the year. Honor it. The wrap-up is also recovery; do not pile on new reflection demands. Allow extended silent scanning. “*You did that work*” is the message. Display all Unit 2 charts simultaneously, including Crisis Resources, for U2·L7 only.

Impact vs. Intent

Both are real · Only one determines what repair addresses

INTENT · WHAT WAS MEANT	IMPACT · WHAT WAS FELT
What was in the mind of the person who acted.	What was experienced by the person who was affected.
Matters for understanding.	Determines what repair addresses.
Helps us know what kind of conversation this is.	Doesn't require permission to be real.

*“If I accidentally step on your foot, I didn’t intend to hurt you. But your foot hurts. **My responsibility is for that impact** — even when my intent was not harmful.”*

THIS GOES BOTH WAYS

When you cause impact — you are responsible for the impact, even if your intent was good. “I didn’t mean to” is honest, and it is not the end of the conversation.

When someone else causes impact on you — your hurt is real, even if their intent was good. “They didn’t mean to” does not erase what you felt. *Both can be true.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This chart is critical for autistic students in *both* directions: (1) They are often told “*they didn’t mean it that way*” when they raise a hurt — the chart says their hurt is still real. (2) They may unknowingly cause impact through communication style differences — the chart says intent does not erase impact, AND impact does not erase the truth that they did not mean harm. Both halves matter. Without the added panel, the chart can be weaponized against the autistic student in either direction. Keep all of Unit 3.

Three Sides of Every Story

The third side is the hardest — and the most important

SIDE 1 · YOUR SIDE

What you experienced. What you felt.
What you needed.

SIDE 2 · THEIR SIDE

What they experienced. What they
felt. What they needed.

**SIDE 3 · COMPASSIONATE OBSERVER
★**

What someone who cares about both
people would see — that neither can
see from where they stand.

“Seeing someone’s perspective is not agreeing with what they did.”

A NOTE ON PERSPECTIVE-TAKING

Imagining someone else’s side is a real skill — and it costs effort. For some students, it takes a long time to do well. **That is not a deficit.** Side 3 — the compassionate observer — is the goal. You do not have to *feel* the other person’s feeling to construct what they may have experienced. Constructed empathy is still empathy.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The “double-empathy problem” research is relevant here: empathy gaps between autistic and non-autistic people run in both directions, and the burden of perspective-taking has historically been placed on autistic students only. The added panel names *constructed empathy* as a valid path — autistic students often build empathy through deliberate construction rather than automatic feeling, and this is no less real. Side 3 — the compassionate observer — is achievable through construction. Keep posted through U3·L3.

Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation

The most important conceptual distinction of Unit 3

FORGIVENESS	RECONCILIATION
Internal psychological process.	Restoration of a relationship.
Choosing to release resentment.	A separate, external decision.
For your own sake — not theirs.	Requires both people’s readiness.
Requires nothing from the other person.	Requires demonstrated behavioral change.
A gift you give yourself.	Earned — never obligatory.
Can happen alone, in your own heart.	Requires both people.

“You can forgive someone **and still choose never to be in a relationship with them again.**”

PATTERNS ARE INFORMATION · BOUNDARY

One harm + real change = one event. **Repeated harm + repeated apology + no change = a pattern.** Patterns are not single events. You are allowed to notice them. *This curriculum never requires forgiveness in situations involving ongoing harm.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The Pattern panel is essential. Autistic adolescents are statistically more likely to be targeted by manipulation and slower to recognize patterns of friendship-harm — partly because they are often coached to “give people another chance” and partly because pattern detection of social dynamics is genuinely harder when you also have to consciously construct what people meant. The panel teaches that distinguishing single events from patterns is a skill, not a failure of generosity. Color-code columns. Keep all of Unit 3.

Flame vs. Pause

React vs. respond · The echo dies when no one feeds it

REACT · FLAME	RESPOND · PAUSE
Feeding the fire.	Ask: what do I actually want to happen here?
Fast. Emotion-driven.	Slow enough to choose.
Makes it worse — even when it feels right.	Minimum effective action.

THE PAUSE — FOUR STEPS

- 1. **STOP.** Before sending, posting, or responding.
- 2. **ASK.** What do I actually want to happen here?
- 3. **CONSIDER.** What will this action cause — in an hour, in a week?
- 4. **CHOOSE.** Minimum effective response — or disengage entirely.

A NOTE ON DYSREGULATION

The Pause requires a regulated nervous system. When you are in shutdown, meltdown, or sensory overload, the Pause is temporarily inaccessible — and that is not a failure of character. **The Pause comes back after regulation.** Step zero, then, is: *regulate first. Pause second.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The autism-specific addition is the regulation prerequisite. For autistic students, asking for a “pause” during a meltdown is asking for something neurologically unavailable. The chart now reflects this. Many students will need explicit support to leave a situation before the Pause is even possible — that is not avoidance; it is sequencing. Post Day 1 of U3·L4. Permanent from this point forward.

Rumour & Narrative Hijack

Two lines · Reference existing charts

Lesson 5 is the most private lesson of Unit 3. Visual environment stays quiet — no new permanent chart.

“A rumour is a story told about you by people who are not primarily concerned with whether it is true.”

“The rumour is not you. It is a story someone else is telling.”

REFERENCE

U3·L1 — Impact vs. Intent

U3·L4 — Flame vs. Pause (permanent)

A NOTE FOR AUTISTIC STUDENTS

Rumours about autistic students often contain a particular kind of distortion: a true behavior is described in a way that makes it sound deliberately rude, mean, or weird. **The behavior may be real. The framing is the rumour.** “She didn’t say hi” might be a real moment. “She is stuck-up” is the story added on top. *You are not responsible for the story. You are responsible only for what you actually did.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Lesson 5 is one of the most painful lessons of Unit 3 for autistic students, who are statistically more likely to be the subject of rumour-shaped social harm. The added panel names the specific shape autistic rumour often takes: a real behavior, distorted into a character claim. This is the most concise piece of self-defense the chart can offer. Two lines on the board; reference existing charts. Keep environment quiet.

The Agency of Release

Crisis resources visible · Letter templates face-down · Counselor present

IF YOU OR SOMEONE YOU KNOW IS IN CRISIS

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — *Call or text 988*

Crisis Text Line — *Text HOME to 741741*

YOUR SCHOOL COUNSELOR

Name: _____

Contact: _____

A NOTE FOR ANYONE WRITING THE LETTER OF RELEASE

The letter is private. **You do not have to share it with anyone — not the teacher, not the counselor, not your parent.** Writing it does not mean you have to send it. Many letters are never sent — the writing is the work, not the sending.

If the letter is about a harm that is still happening — please tell a trusted adult about the harm. *The letter alone does not stop ongoing harm.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The Letter of Release lesson can surface real material — sometimes including disclosures of ongoing harm. Autistic students may write very literally what is happening to them when given an unstructured private writing prompt. The added panel reinforces privacy AND adds the disclosure prompt about ongoing harm. The room must be calm. Counselor physically in the room before the first student enters. Letter templates face-down at seats. Crisis resources visible. Permanent posting for the rest of the year.

Limits

Setting limits is an act of self-respect — not retaliation

THE FORMULA

“When you ___, I ___. Going forward, I need ___.”

LIMIT	THREAT
Information about what I need to be okay.	A demand the other person suffer.
A statement about what I will do.	Punishment disguised as a limit.
From a place of self-respect.	From a place of retaliation.
Focused on what I can control.	Focused on what I want done to them.

“A limit is not a punishment. It is not an ultimatum. It is a statement about what **YOU** will do — which you can actually control.”

A NOTE ON ACCOMMODATIONS AS LIMITS

Asking for what you need to be okay is a limit too. “I need to step out when the lights start humming.” “I need my headphones during the assembly.” “I do not do group work in big rooms — I will work with one partner in a quieter space.” These are not special favors. *They are accurate descriptions of what you need to function — which is information any reasonable system should welcome.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The added panel explicitly frames sensory and processing accommodations as a category of limit. Many autistic students have been taught — explicitly or implicitly — that asking for accommodation is asking for special treatment. The panel reframes accommodation requests as the same skill the lesson teaches everyone else: *naming what you need to be okay*. Post Day 1 of U3·L7. Permanent from this point.

What Is Grace?

Grace is not sentimentality · It is chosen strength

GRACE — IN THIS CURRICULUM

The deliberate choice to extend something generous — patience, inclusion, the benefit of the doubt — to someone who has not necessarily earned it.

THREE REGISTERS OF DIFFICULTY

- 1. **Grace that is EASY.** Toward someone you like, or who has been kind to you.
- 2. **Grace that COSTS something.** Toward someone neutral or unfamiliar.
- 3. **Grace that is HARD.** Toward someone who has not been kind to you.

GRACE IS A CHOICE — AND CHOICE HAS LIMITS

Grace is voluntary. It is not the same as being told to “*be nice*” to someone who is hurting you. **You are allowed to extend less grace — or none — to people who have repeatedly harmed you.** This is preserved in Unit 4·L5 (Difficult vs. Unsafe). The third register — grace that is HARD — is about people who are *difficult*, not *unsafe*.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The added panel is a load-bearing clarification. Without it, the “grace is hard” register can land on autistic students as “*you should be generous to the people who bully you*” — which is exactly what they have been told their whole lives. The chart says clearly: grace is a choice, and choice excludes coercion. Post before class. Permanently prominent through U4·L7.

What Is Mercy?

The choice to restrain power — withholding a response that would be justified

MERCY — IN THIS CURRICULUM

Restraining power you could legitimately use — because something more important than being right is at stake: the person’s capacity to grow.

MERCY · CHOOSING KINDNESS	JUSTICE · MATCHING CONSEQUENCE
Choosing kindness when harshness would be justified.	Consequences that match the harm caused.
Holds the relationship and the room.	Holds the standard and the truth.
Costs something of the person who extends it.	Necessary, not optional, in many cases.

“This tension is real. This lesson does not resolve it. It asks you to sit with it.”

A NOTE FOR STUDENTS WITH STRONG JUSTICE-SENSITIVITY

Some students have a strong internal sense that *fair is fair*, and may find this lesson genuinely difficult. **That is not a problem to fix.** Justice-sensitivity is a strength. The lesson is not asking you to abandon it — it is asking you to recognize that *another value can also be true at the same time*. Both can hold.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

Many autistic students have strong justice-sensitivity and will resist this lesson on principle. The added panel honors that resistance rather than treating it as something to overcome. Sitting in the tension between mercy and justice is the lesson — the student who refuses to dissolve the tension is doing the lesson correctly, not failing it. Keep posted Unit 4.

The Pause — Charitable Interpretation

Step 0 added to the existing Flame vs. Pause chart from U3·L4

ADD TO THE EXISTING U3·L4 FLAME VS. PAUSE CHART

Step 0 — Charitable Interpretation. Before you do anything — choose the most generous available explanation. Until you have evidence that it is wrong.

THEN STEPS 1–4 CONTINUE AS DRAWN ON THE EXISTING CHART

1. STOP. 2. ASK. 3. CONSIDER. 4. CHOOSE.

“We automatically give charitable interpretation to people we like. **That’s where the real practice begins.**”

UNTIL YOU HAVE EVIDENCE THAT IT IS WRONG

The phrase “until you have evidence that it is wrong” is doing the heavy lifting in Step 0. **The charitable interpretation is the starting position — not the final answer.** If someone keeps hurting you, the evidence has accumulated. Trust it. *Your read of the pattern is data.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This is the second most important adaptation in Book Three (after Mask vs. Mirror). The original Step 0 — taught without the guardrail — can train autistic students to repeatedly choose the generous interpretation in the face of accumulating evidence of harm. The added panel makes explicit that charitable interpretation is a *starting* position, not a destination, and that evidence accumulates. Add Step 0 directly to the existing U3·L4 chart. Already permanent.

Micro-Moment Menu

Specific grace acts — choose three for the Grace Challenge

SPECIFIC GRACE ACTS — CHOOSE THREE

- ✓ Say the NAME of the person you sit next to when you greet them.
- ✓ Show you’re listening — your way. (Nod, look toward, repeat back, write a note — whatever signals listening for you.)
- ✓ Let someone go FIRST when you could have gone first.
- ✓ Remember something someone told you — and bring it back to them.
- ✓ Acknowledge someone’s contribution BEFORE adding your own.
- ✓ Notice when someone is LEFT OUT and move toward them.
- ✓ Ask one FOLLOW-UP QUESTION after someone shares something.
- ✓ Sit next to someone who is sitting alone.

Being nicer *is not a micro-moment.* **Specificity is the key requirement.**

THREE TESTS

Can I do this in 30 seconds? · Does it cost me something? · Can I observe whether I did it?

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original Micro-Moment Menu included “*make EYE CONTACT and nod when someone is speaking*” — which pathologizes autistic communication. We replaced it with “**Show you’re listening — your way**” with explicit examples of valid alternatives. Listening looks different in different bodies. A student who looks at the wall while you talk may be listening more carefully than the student who maintains eye contact. The behavioral equivalent of “showing you’re listening” is preserved; the neurotypical performance is not required. Keep posted Unit 4.

Difficult vs. Unsafe

This distinction changes everything about what the right response is

EASY · WELCOME THE PERSON

Someone you like, or who has been kind to you. Grace is automatic.

DIFFICULT · PRACTICE GRACE

Irritating. Challenging. Hard to be around. *Grace is appropriate and possible.*

UNSAFE · PROTECT YOURSELF

Active harm. Ongoing danger. **Safety — not grace — is the priority.**

“Grace is not required toward unsafe people. Ever.”

DIFFICULT VS. UNSAFE — A WORKING TEST

Difficult means: this person is hard to be around, but I leave the interaction with my dignity intact.

Unsafe means: this person leaves me smaller, scared, or hurt — and the pattern repeats. *“They’re just having a bad day” stops being a reasonable explanation when the pattern is consistent.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original chart left “difficult vs. unsafe” as a conceptual distinction. The added panel gives autistic students a **working test** — concrete, observable criteria they can apply to a specific person in their life. Many autistic students struggle with the abstract version; given concrete criteria, they can usually answer immediately. Keep posted Unit 4.

Grace Gap

What to look for — reference during the observation phase of the final project

A GRACE GAP

Where the absence of grace creates a noticeably harder experience for someone.

OBSERVE · PEOPLE

Who is consistently left out? Who is not receiving charitable interpretation?

OBSERVE · PATTERNS

Where is impatience the default? What goes consistently unacknowledged?

OBSERVE · MOMENTS

Where could one person's inclusion change another's experience?

GOOD AUDIT CRITERIA

Specific · Observable · Actionable · Empathic

A NOTE FROM THE TEAM

Autistic students often see the Grace Gap with unusual clarity — they have lived in it. **If a student names a Grace Gap that they themselves are inside, do not redirect.** Their observation is data. Honor it. Then ask gently: “*What would change this?*”

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The Grace Gap project asks students to audit social environments — and autistic students are particularly well-positioned to identify gaps because they are statistically more often the recipient of them. The added panel instructs the teacher to honor the autistic student who names their own experience as a Grace Gap, rather than reframing the observation. *If a student says “people don’t sit with me at lunch,” the right response is not “have you tried sitting with them?” — it is “thank you for naming that. What would change it?”* Post during the observation phase.

Community Charter

Co-created and signed by this class — displayed permanently

This chart is created by students during the lesson · Do not pre-write it · The co-creation process is the lesson

THE CHARTER INCLUDES

- 1. Commitment sentences — one per student, generated and chosen by them.
- 2. Every student’s signature — all names, none excluded.
- 3. The date — the day this room agreed to this.

A NOTE ON THE SIGNATURE LINE

For some students, signing their name in front of the whole class is genuinely hard — autistic students may need to sign in a quieter moment, or to draw a symbol instead, or to have a peer sign on their behalf with permission. **All of these are valid signatures.** The point is presence, not the calligraphy of presence. *None excluded means none excluded — including the student for whom the standard signing process is too much.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

The original instruction — “every student’s signature” — is the right instruction, but the default mechanism (signing in front of the class) excludes some autistic students whose sensory and social load is already maxed at year-end. The added panel preserves the principle while expanding the mechanism. After the lesson, display permanently and photograph for the district adoption file. The Charter is the year’s closing artifact.

A Note to the Teacher

What Book Three asks of you

Middle school is the highest-stakes section of the curriculum for autistic students. Masking peaks here. Friendships shift from interest-based to status-based. Sensory load is high. **You may be teaching this curriculum to autistic students who do not look autistic to you** — and who are doing more work to be in your room than you can see.

This supplement preserves your curriculum and adds scaffolding into Tier 1 design. Every neurotypical student benefits from the same accommodations — that is universal design. We did not lower the ceiling. We added more ways to reach it.

What we ask you to honor

- **Unmasking is welcome.** Stimming, looking elsewhere, fidgeting, quiet — all are forms of presence.
- **Constructed empathy is empathy.** A student who builds perspective through deliberate effort is doing the work, not faking it.
- **Justice-sensitivity is a strength.** A student who refuses to dissolve the tension between mercy and justice is doing Unit 4 correctly.
- **Patterns are intelligence.** A student who names a Grace Gap they live inside is naming data.
- **Regulation precedes the Pause.** A student in shutdown cannot execute the four steps. The chart returns when the nervous system does.
- **Accommodations are limits.** Naming what you need to function is the same skill the curriculum teaches.

What we ask you to never do

- Never tell an autistic student that grace toward someone who has harmed them is the right answer. Grace is a choice. Difficult is not unsafe.
- Never require eye contact as evidence of attention.
- Never frame masking as maturity. It is survival behavior with a real cost.
- Never reframe a student's accurate read of a pattern as "you should give people the benefit of the doubt." They already did. The doubt is now data.

A FINAL WORD

The original *Architecture of Grace · The Interior* is a serious piece of work, and the adolescents in your room are lucky to have it. This supplement exists because every student — autistic and otherwise — deserves a curriculum that meets them where their nervous system actually lives. *Thank you for the work you do. It matters more than the day will let you see.*